

Chapter 115_2 - Grievance

"Fine, just don't do it again in the future." Ning Fuyi withdrew her gaze and raised her hand slightly. Only then did Du Baishuang rise like she'd received a great pardon, sobbing silently.

The familiar scent of gardenia flowers drifted through the door crack. Ning Fuyi's heartstrings tightened. She waved her hand to put away those books and reached out: "Come here."

Though Du Baishuang didn't understand, she still obediently came forward, wiped away her tears and sat beside her, leaning into her arms and looking up at her.

"Hall Master keeps this slave because... this slave resembles the Divine Venerable somewhat?" Du Baishuang suddenly asked.

Ning Fuyi originally wanted to explain, but then felt there was no real need to explain, so she hummed in agreement and reached for the fruit wine on the table, slowly drinking it down.

Du Baishuang's peach blossom eyes drooped, and her hands encircled Ning Fuyi's slender waist.

The door suddenly opened. The woman's veil was blown up on one side by the wind, revealing half a face that was naturally beautiful without makeup. Rich floral fragrance blew in from the doorframe, crisp and pleasant.

Before opening the door, Chu Qingqiu had imagined what she might witness, but after the door opened, her heart still twisted painfully, causing her brow to furrow tightly.

Ning Fuyi's hand holding the wine cup paused slightly. Her phoenix eyes lifted, and the two gazed at each other across the veil.

The music became somewhat blurred for a moment, then grew loud again.

Ning Fuyi put down her wine cup and smiled with lowered head: "Barging into my territory so brazenly - even for a Divine Venerable, this isn't proper etiquette, is it?"

The dancing girls around continued swaying to the music. Someone brought over a plate of refreshments, smiled at Ning Fuyi, then spun around and left.

Chu Qingqiu took in the scene before her, finally forcing her gaze away from Du Baishuang: "I want to talk with you."

Ning Fuyi let out a light laugh. She reached out to pick up a piece of refreshment and brought it to Du Baishuang's lips. Du Baishuang parted her red lips and licked the treat into her mouth.

This action looked ambiguous no matter how one viewed it. Chu Qingqiu's nails nearly dug into her palms as she stared fixedly at Ning Fuyi through her veil.

"Very well. For the sake of my once being a disciple of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, whatever the Divine Venerable wishes to discuss, I'll accompany you." Ning Fuyi smiled, the floral ornament¹ between her brows bright as blood.

"Are you truly like this, or are you putting on an act for someone to see?" Chu Qingqiu spoke.

Ning Fuyi's eyebrows, thin as crescents, twitched slightly. As if hearing something amusing, she covered her lips and laughed, lowering her head to smooth the hair of the woman in her arms: "Putting on an act? For whom? For you?"

"Don't jest. The Divine Venerable's heart encompasses all living beings under heaven. How could you care about a mere junior like me? You have purified your six senses², while I'm just an ordinary person. When ordinary people do ordinary things, does it violate the Heavenly Dao³?"

Ning Fuyi shook her head, placing her hand on Du Baishuang's waist and pressing the soft, boneless woman closer into her embrace. Du Baishuang obediently leaned against her chest and looked up to say something.

"Hall Master, I'm thirsty."

Ning Fuyi curved her lips at her and reached for the wine cup. Chu Qingqiu could bear it no longer and raised her voice: "Ning Fuyi! So many people are watching your every move right now, and Penglai is searching for your traces throughout the world, yet you indulge in pleasure here - how is this appropriate!"

Ning Fuyi coldly raised her eyes, suddenly slapping her hand on the table. A gust of wind rose from beneath Chu Qingqiu's feet, immediately blowing away her bamboo hat along with her veil.

Eyes bright as a new moon showed traces of red, all her features exposed under the lamplight. Chu Qingqiu didn't dodge, letting the veil fall to the ground as her hair brushed past her nose.

Though her face bore seven or eight parts resemblance to Du Baishuang, the different three parts showed additional coldness and determination. With this comparison, they became two completely different people.

"What's wrong with indulging? Do you think everyone is like you? Since you rejected my feelings back then, I left. Why have you come looking for me now? You wouldn't deign to look at me even unto death, and now I don't want to look at you anymore either. Shouldn't you feel happy?"

Ning Fuyi's words were harsh. Only when she saw that the red in Chu Qingqiu's eyes could no longer be suppressed did she slowly exhale and curve her lips in a shallow smile again.

She picked up the wine cup and brought it to Du Baishuang's lips, watching her drink carefully before setting down the cup and using her hand to wipe away the remaining wine stains at the corners of her mouth.

"Besides, how do you know I'm merely playing around?" Ning Fuyi hooked Du Baishuang's chin, her lips lowering slightly as she used her surging resentment to voice all her harsh words: "You know how precious spirit clan members like her are. What cultivation method could compare to this?"

Upon hearing this, Chu Qingqiu could no longer suppress the fire in her heart: "Ning Fuyi!"

She steadfastly refused to believe Ning Fuyi would truly be like this, but when such scenes actually appeared before her eyes, she truly became afraid - afraid that Ning Fuyi had really gone astray and was no longer Ning Fuyi.

Beyond that, the excruciating pain of watching her be gentle with others spread throughout her entire chest, hurting so much she could barely breathe.

"You cannot." She said in a low voice, closing her eyes and bowing her head. "You cannot be like this."

This time Ning Fuyi truly laughed: "Cannot? Do you think you can still control me? Divine Venerable Chu Ling."

Her phoenix eyes glowed red as she stared at Chu Qingqiu. The woman stood straight and tall, yet seemed to be standing in the wind, looking as if she might be blown away.

"Perhaps there's still one way." Ning Fuyi lowered her head to hide her emotions. She raised her hand to release Du Baishuang, stood up and walked around the stone table toward Chu Qingqiu standing by the door.

After stopping in front of her, she finally raised her head and waved her sleeves. All the dancing girls and musicians in the hall dispersed, leaving only the two of them.

Chu Qingqiu's eyes were already moist, a teardrop squeezed out from her eye socket and slid bit by bit to her chin. Though her eyes remained cold, she looked more grieved than anything.

Ning Fuyi's gaze flickered. She reached into Chu Qingqiu's sleeve and forcefully pulled out the white bone weapon she held tightly in her palm, ready to strike, clattering it to the ground.

Then she casually wiped away that tear and smoothly lifted the woman's moist chin.

"Your turn." She said.

Footnotes

¹ **Floral ornament (花钿)** - A decorative mark or ornament worn on the forehead, typically by women in ancient China. It was often made of gold, silver, or painted directly on the skin and came in various floral designs.

² **Six senses (六根)** - In Buddhism, these refer to the six sense organs: eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and mind. "Purifying the six senses" means achieving detachment from worldly desires and sensations.

³ **Heavenly Dao (天道)** - The Way of Heaven, representing the natural order and moral principles that govern the universe in Chinese philosophy and cultivation fiction.